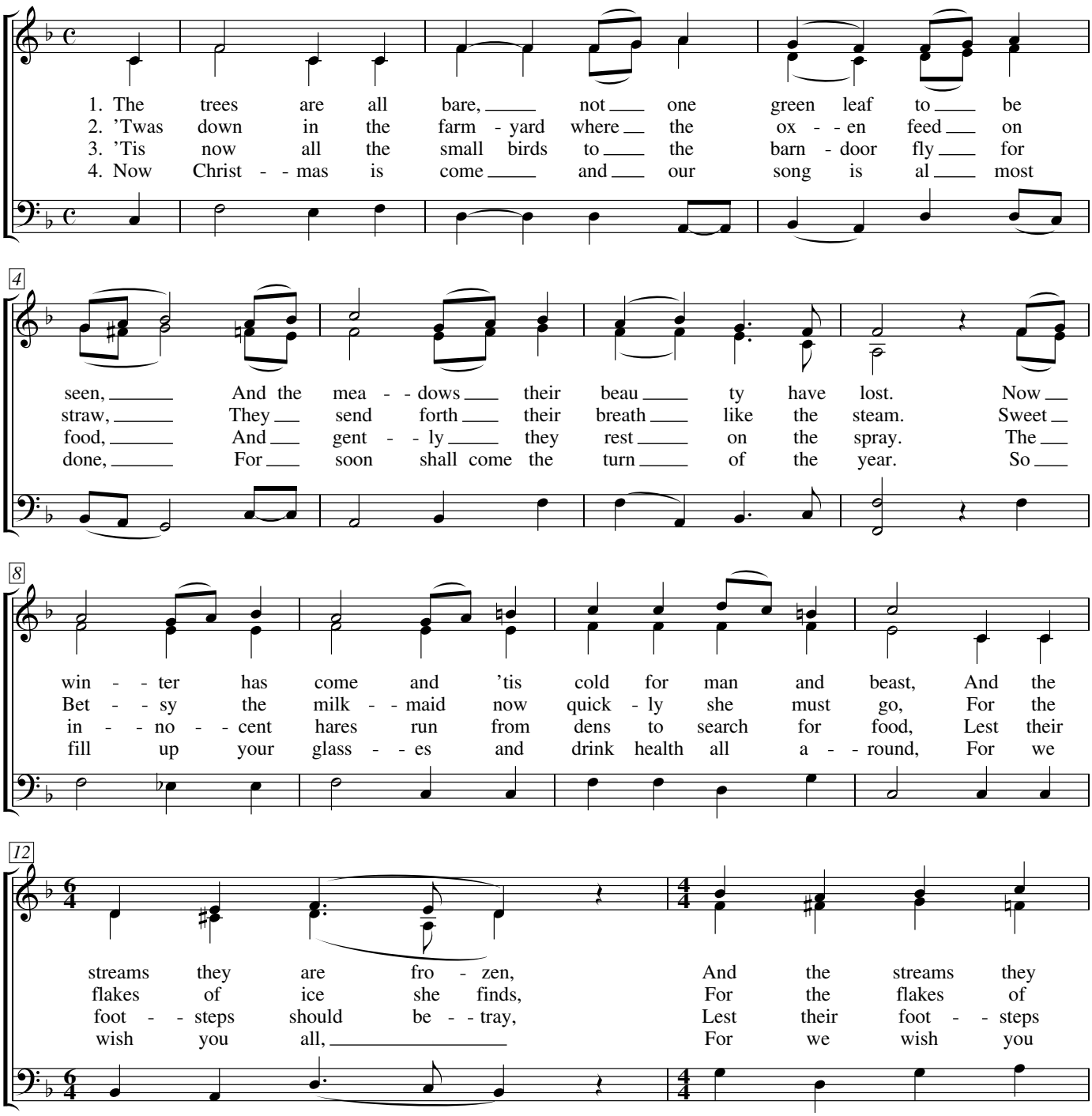
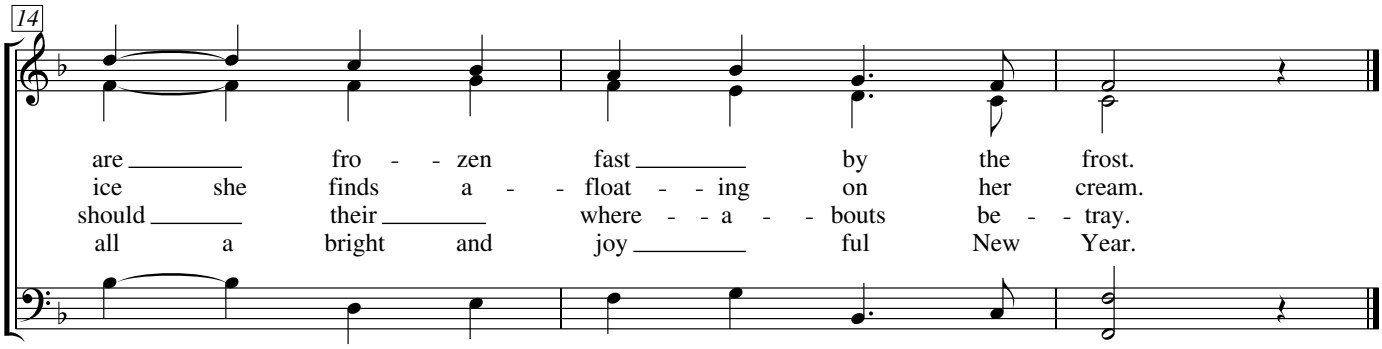
The Trees Are All Bare

Sussex (traditional)



1. The trees all are bare, not one green leaf to be seen,
   And the meadows their beauty have lost.
   Now winter has come and 'tis cold for man and beast,
   And the streams they are frozen,
   The streams they are frozen fast by the frost.

2. 'Twas down in the farmyard where the oxen feed on straw,
   They send forth their breath like the steam.
   Sweet Betsy the milkmaid now quickly she must go,
   For the flakes of ice she finds,
   For the flakes of ice she finds a-floating on her cream.

3. 'Tis now all the small birds to the barn-door fly for food,
   And gently they rest on the spray.
   The innocent hares run from dens to search for food,
   Lest their footsteps should betray
   Lest their footsteps should their whereabouts betray

4. Now Christmas is come and our song is almost done,
   For soon shall come the turn of the year.
   So fill up your glasses and drink health all around,
   For we wish you all
   For we wish you all a bright and joyful New Year

Unknown outside of Sussex until recent times, this song appears to derive from 'Winter', a poem written by Thomas Brerewood of Horton, Cheshire (d. 1748). Known traditional singers include the Downs shepherd, Michael Blann from Upper Beeding, whose MS songbook is in the Sussex Library; George Townshend of Lewes, Sussex who was recorded in the 1960s; and the Copper Family from Rottingdean, Sussex. Roud Index 1170.

Our lyrics are an amalgam of the words sung by Bob Copper on the Copper Family's 1971 recording, "A Song For Every Season" with a version recorded on Jackie Oates & John Spiers 2024 recording, "A Midwinter's Night". The tune hews close to the Copper Family's version.